

AGE OF MYTHOS

West — Chapter 1 — Rise of Legends

West · Paschima · English Edition

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Maru Maya — The War Against Sand Itself

There is a Rajasthani proverb: "The desert does not hate you. The desert does not love you. The desert does not know you exist." Mrigatrishna knows this is a lie. The desert knows exactly who she is, and it is coming for her.

Maru-Rakshasa first appeared during the longest drought in Rajasthan's recorded history. Wells dried. Rivers vanished. The chinkaras — those delicate desert gazelles that can survive on dew alone — began dying. When even the chinkara cannot survive, the desert has declared war on the living.

He rose from a dune like a man standing up from a nap, except the man was twelve feet tall and made entirely of sand. His eyes were two smooth stones — the kind you find in riverbeds that no longer exist. He walked toward Jaisalmer and the sand walked with him, flowing around his feet like an obedient ocean.

Mrigatrishna tried her tricks. Smoke bombs — the wind scattered them. Mirror daggers — sand has no reflection to confuse. Misdirection — the sandstorm sees in all directions simultaneously.

The Battle of the Glass Dunes was named for what happened when Maru-Rakshasa's sandstorm met the fire-arrows of the Jaisalmer garrison: the sand fused into glass in mid-air, creating a rain of razor-sharp shards that cut friend and foe alike. Mrigatrishna lost seventeen of her best spies that night. The Great Indian Bustard — the last male of the species in that region — was seen flying away from the battlefield, and the Bustard-Seeker wept, saying the omen was clear: retreat or die.

But retreat is not in the Rajput vocabulary. Mrigatrishna retreated anyway, because she is not a Rajput traditionalist — she is a survivor.

In the ruins of an abandoned haveli, she found Meera Bai's Ghost singing to an empty courtyard. The ghost sang of Krishna and devotion, but beneath the melody was a coded message: the sand has no power over water. Not literal water — the desert had none — but the memory of water. Every well in Rajasthan, even the dry ones, remembers being full. And memory, in this world of tattoos and sacred beasts, is power.

Mrigatrishna is now searching for the seven ancient stepwells of Rajasthan — the baolis built so deep they touched the underground rivers. If she can awaken the memory of water

in those stones, the desert itself will remember what it was before it was sand: a green, living land.

Maru-Rakshasa knows this and guards the baolis with sandstorms. The chinkara on Mrigatrishna's arm flickers between solid and dissolving — the tattoo itself caught between water's memory and sand's reality.

The war continues, and the desert watches.

Samudra Dvipa — The Fleet Of The Drowned

Goa has always been a place between worlds. Between sea and land, between East and West, between the temples in the hills and the churches on the coast. This in-between quality is its strength and its vulnerability — for things that exist between worlds can be pulled in either direction.

Sagaradeva understood this instinctively. Born on water, raised between fishing nets and temple bells, he learned early that balance is not stillness — it is constant, exhausting adjustment. His cutlass Samudra and his chain Lahara are not just weapons; they are the two pulls of his life — the ocean that calls him and the land that needs him.

The night the ghost fleet appeared, every bulbul in Goa sang at once. Ruby-throated yellow bulbuls do not sing at night — but the dead ships' lanterns confused them into thinking dawn had come. Fifty vessels, crewed by drowned warriors whose half-formed tattoos glowed sickly green in the darkness, sailed into the mouth of the Mandovi river.

Samudra-Daitya stood at the prow of the lead ship, and he was laughing. Not the laugh of a conqueror — the laugh of a man who has found a loophole in death itself.

The battle in the harbor was chaos. You cannot kill what is already dead. Sagaradeva's sailors fought bravely but their blades passed through ghost-flesh like water through a net. Only when Padre Velha rang the bell of his sea-cave chapel — a bell forged from both temple bronze and church brass — did the ghost sailors flinch. The sound of both faiths combined was the one frequency that reminded them of what they were: dead, and wrongly kept from rest.

Sagaradeva used that moment. He dove into the harbor, chain in hand, and wrapped Lahara around the anchor of the ghost-flagship. The gaur tattoo on his arm blazed — the bull does not charge unless provoked, but once provoked, it does not stop. He pulled. The chain sang with tension. And the flagship capsized, spilling ghost sailors into the harbor where Padre Velha's bell-sound dissolved them into sea-foam.

Samudra-Daitya escaped on a smaller vessel. His fleet scattered but did not sink — ghost ships cannot sink twice.

Now Goa's harbors are guarded by bells that ring with two faiths' resonance, and the bulbuls have learned to sing at the first sign of ghost-light. Sagaradeva patrols the coast

nightly, his chain dragging in the water behind his boat, feeling for the vibration of dead keels beneath the surface.

The gaur on his arm has grown — the horns now reach his shoulder. The half-body mark approaches, but its price is clear: he must face the ghost fleet one more time, and this time, he must go under the water to find the sunken temple where Samudra-Daitya builds his new ships from drowned men's bones.

Simha Dwara — Two Lions One Throne

The Gir Forest holds the last Asiatic lions on Earth. Once they roamed from Greece to Bengal — now they survive in a single forest in Gujarat. This fact haunts every lion-bearer of the kingdom: we are the last. If we fall, the line ends forever.

Simhavikrama took this burden and turned it into ambition. If the lion is the last, then the lion must be the strongest. He forged Simhagarjana from the iron of ancient trading ships — Gujarat's merchant heritage melted into a warrior's weapon. He trained until the sword felt lighter than a feather, and then he trained some more. When the lion tattoo covered his entire body — the earliest full-body mark in his generation — the Gir lions roared for a full day. Even the flamingos in the Rann of Kutch turned their heads south.

Mrugendra heard the roar and felt nothing. He had been the firstborn, the expected heir, the one who should have carried the lion. But the tattoo is not inherited — it is earned. And Mrugendra's gifts were not the gifts of roaring. His gifts were listening, planning, and the terrible patience of a hunter who waits until the prey has forgotten to be afraid.

He built his resistance in the Rann of Kutch — that vast white salt desert where nothing grows and everything is visible. An army hidden in a place where nothing can hide should be impossible. But Mrugendra's Silent Army wears white salt-crusted armor and moves only at night, when the flamingos sleep and the salt glows like moonlit snow.

Their first strike was at the Port of Lothal — Gujarat's greatest trading harbor. Without a single battle cry, without a single clash of steel, every ship in the harbor found its anchor chains cut and its cargo hold opened. A hundred tons of grain — Simhavikrama's war supplies — floated out to sea. By dawn, the flamingos were feeding on grain-fish attracted by the spillage, and Mrugendra's message was clear: your strength feeds no one.

Simhavikrama responded with fury. He led the Gir lions into the salt desert, and the battle that followed was unlike any in Indian history — a roaring army of men and beasts charging across white salt under moonlight, pursuing shadows that made no sound. The lions could not track what they could not hear. Simhavikrama could not command what could not hear him.

The brothers have not met face-to-face since childhood. Mrugendra sends messages through flamingos — pink birds carrying white scrolls. Simhavikrama reads them,

crumples them, and roars at the sea.

Dwarka-Nath watches from his floating temple and says: "The sunken city drowned because its king trusted his own strength more than his people's wisdom. The sea does not care how loudly you roar."

But neither brother is listening. And the Gir lions pace their forest, sensing that the pride is about to split — and a divided pride does not survive.

Swarajya Sahyadri — The War Of Brother And Sister

Maharashtra has three hundred and fifty forts. Some stand proud on mountain peaks, some crouch in river valleys, and some have been swallowed by jungle so thick that you could walk past them without knowing a wall stands ten feet away. Shivagati has set foot on every single one.

She learned to climb before she learned to walk — her mother used to say she crawled up walls before she crawled on floors. The Giant Squirrel tattoo appeared on her back the day she scaled Raigad Fort at age fourteen, bare-handed, in the monsoon rain, to plant her clan's flag at the summit. The squirrel's tail wrapped around her neck that night, and she felt the mark warm against her skin like a living thing.

Ranveer was twenty then, and already bitter. He had trained harder, climbed higher, fought longer — but the tattoo chose his younger sister. In Maharashtra, the squirrel chooses. You cannot earn it. You cannot demand it. And Ranveer could not accept it.

He left on a morning so still that even the green pigeons stopped their cooing. He took his hooks, his knowledge of every secret passage in the Sahyadri forts, and his rage. Within a year, he had sold the location of three hidden armories to rival kingdoms. Within two years, two forts fell — not because their walls were breached, but because their secret entrances were revealed.

Shivagati hunted him. She found him at Sindhudurg, the sea-fort that had never been taken. He was sitting on the highest wall, dangling his legs over the Arabian Sea, eating a mango.

"You're too late, little squirrel," he said. "I've already sold the maps."

Their fight lasted four hours, moving vertically across the fort's walls, hooks sparking against stone. They knew each other's moves perfectly — every feint, every drop, every swing. The battle ended in a draw when Ranveer's barbed hook caught in the stone and snapped. He fell into the sea.

He survived. He always survives.

Now he operates from the shadows, selling fort-secrets to anyone who will pay. Shivagati has sealed thirty-seven secret passages and refortified nine compromised positions. But Maharashtra has three hundred and fifty forts, and Ranveer knows them all.

The green pigeons have been seen carrying tiny scrolls in their beaks — messages from Samarth Ramdas's cave-echoes, warning Shivagati of the next betrayal. But the echoes speak in riddles, and by the time she decodes them, Ranveer has already moved on.

She does not want to kill her brother. But the mountain demands it. And in the Sahyadris, the mountain always gets what it wants.